

Black- and red-figure pottery

Black-figure pottery is a style of Greek pottery painting that was common between the seventh and fifth centuries BCE. Artists painted or incised fine details with sharp implements onto red clay vessels, then painted them using clay, water and wood ash, leaving the background red. Artists fired the vessels in three stages, closing all the openings of the kiln. The lack of air made the pots turn black. When air was allowed in again, the painted parts remained black and the rest returned to red.

Around 510 BCE, red-figure pottery became more popular. It contrasted with the black-figure style as figures and shapes were the red of the clay, while backgrounds were painted black. These were created with the same method as black-figure pottery, only details were outlined in black using a fine brush rather than a sharp tool, making curves and details easier to apply. Patterns and pictures also contrasted more vividly against black backgrounds, so red-figure pottery was more expressive. Both styles depicted scenes from Greek mythology or daily life.



Red and black figure plates, c.520-500 BCE